Chapter Three: Damage Control

The mere whiff of a breach acts like nerve poison on intelligence agencies. If you lose even a single document, or believe an unauthorised person has had access to it, assumptions must be of worst-case scenarios. Assume that the Russians learn that an outwardly boring Irish insurance broker in the Ukrainian capital Kiev, for example, is actually an undercover officer of Britain's Secret Intelligence Service. What will they be able to do with that information? Will he be in danger? Will they able to find what agents he is running? If so, they must be brought out: they risk arrest. Maybe the agents are safe, but the operation cannot continue: in that case everyone involved must be stood down inconspicuously. What about colleagues? Safe houses? Dead-letter boxes? Another question is when the breach occurred. Can one be sure that this was the first instance? How solid is the 'product' (the intelligence obtained from the compromised network or individual)? Should it be assessed or analysed differently? Is it possible that the adversary used the breach to feed misleading information and then monitor the results? The answers to these questions may be 'no'. But an experienced team of counter-intelligence officers must ask them, find the answers, check and double-check. The taint of even a minor breach must be analysed, contained and cleaned.

If a single breach is a serious problem, two make a nightmare—particularly if the missing material comes from different bits of the organisation. Documents which may on their own be quite anodyne can be gravely damaging if they are combined. Revealing an intelligence officer's cover name may be no big deal. But combined with his previous travel, it could be the clue that gives the adversary details of an operation. Multiple breaches